

IRONROOT Narrative Progression and Disclosure

Slow-burn Morrowind-like literacy, major erasure events, and 100-hour mastery curve.

Purpose: map the discussed mechanics into a slow-burn narrative progression where expert literacy becomes speedrun power.

1. Opening Trauma

The game opens in rain at the grave-orchard. Morrow dies. The spouse's name is carved out of the grave. The debt-spirit is visibly and violently erased. A psychoacoustic Name-Shear plays at full force. No tutorial explains it. The body learns first.

This moment teaches the player that Veyrholt's violence is not just murder. It is record removal. A person can be made to have never been.

2. Progressive Disclosure

Layer	What the Player Receives	What Is Actually Being Taught
Sensory horror	One unforgettable sound	Erasure has a signature.
Pattern	Distant repeats	The world changes after the sound.
Direction	Sound location and timbre	Erasures can be traced.
Schedule	Repeated timing patterns	Faction events are deterministic.
Interruption	Arriving during events	Erasures can be stopped.
Prevention	Beating the event chain	Mastery means stopping the siren before it plays.

3. The Morrowind Principle

The city does not wait for the player. Quests can be solved before they are given. Events can be failed without a failure screen. Directions are local, imperfect, and diegetic. Knowledge is more powerful than stats.

Design law: The game should feel hostile and opaque at first, but never arbitrary. Once the player understands the rules, the world becomes readable like code.

4. Major Erasure Example: Grey Orchard Cleanse

Mastery Level	Experience
Beginner	Hears the siren elsewhere; later finds Grey Orchard empty, graves blank, and dialogue changed.
Intermediate	Follows rumors and arrives during the cleanse; saves one person or recovers residue.
Skilled	Breaks receipt anchors, silences chapel bells, exposes the mason, and fights the cleanse boss.
Speedrunner	Prevents the event from spawning by destroying the hidden ledger chain before the first bell.

5. 100-Hour Narrative Arc

Hours	Narrative State	System State
0-10	The Name Taken	Survival loop, first Shadow stain, first erasures.
10-25	The City Has Clocks	Erasure routing, death-routes, early faction pressure.
25-45	Build Identity	Aspect mastery, oath-weapons, quincunx fights.
45-70	The Shadow Learns	Shadow counters habits, routes, executions, and refusals.
70-90	Faction Pressure	The city acts like a 4X board of cleanses, audits, tolls, and bloodline cuts.
90-100+	What Does Grief Become?	Zodiac endings, no-shear routes, thirteenth refusal.

6. Faction Readability

Faction	Sound / Signal	World Function
Ledger Church	Cathedral bell cracking into static	Turns grief, burial, and debt into enforceable law.
Toll-Saints	Chain-rattle pulse cut short	Controls movement through repeated payment.
Index Monks	Page-flip swarm into silence	Decides which memories remain legally real.
Widow Courts	Drowned vow and water pressure	Controls union, inheritance, and posthumous ownership.
Root-Pruners	Blade-through-bone transient	Removes bloodlines, histories, and timelines.
Hollow Astronomers	Vacuum pulse with missing echo	Breaks correspondence between body, map, and soul.
Free Graves	Wind or no sound	Refusal, debtless dead, unrecorded survival.

7. The Endgame Turn

By the late game, a strong player can route major erasures and prevent village wipes. But the thirteenth path asks a harder question: has the player merely become another perfect function of the system? Saving, optimizing, executing, and routing can all still make grief useful.

Final narrative question: Can the player stop converting pain into power after the entire game has trained them to optimize that conversion?